

Dana Shaat, Ph.D.

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Professional Summary

Applied Microeconomist with a Ph.D. in Economics and four years of experience designing and leading rigorous evaluations in K–12, postsecondary education, and workforce initiatives. Specialized in using data and causal inference methods, including RCTs, quasi-experiments, and advanced statistical techniques, to generate actionable insights for policy and practice. Proven track record in securing multimillion-dollar research funding, directing complex, multi-institutional studies, and delivering high-impact reports and presentations for diverse stakeholders. Strong communicator and project leader, with expertise in translating technical findings into clear, policy-relevant narratives.

Education

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, Ph.D. Economics, 2021

Dissertation Title: Essays on the Economics of Education, Gender, and Public Policy

Committee: Professors Eliza Forsythe, Russell Weinstein, Darren Lubotsky, and Elizabeth Powers

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, M.Sc. Economics, 2017

George Mason University, B.S. Economics, Math minor, August 2014

Technical Skills

Programming: STATA (Adv.), LaTeX (Adv.), Python (Inter.), R (Inter.), Microsoft Excel (Adv.)

Tools: Microsoft Office Suite, AirTable

Methods: Data Analysis, Causal Inference, Econometric Modeling, RCT, Quasi-experimental design, Natural experiments

Project Management: Team Leadership, Budget oversight, Stakeholder engagement, Technical and non-Technical Writing

Employment History

Economist

Digital Services Group, Inc. (DSG) (August 2025 – Present)

- Led and won the proposal effort for a multi-year Institute of Education Sciences (IES) [contract](#) focused on estimating the cost of compliance and accreditation for institutions of higher education.
- Serve as **Project Director**, acting as primary point of contact for the COR at IES; manage a cross-organizational team of ten across DSG and WestEd.
- Co-lead the design and implementation of a national cost study, including development of the conceptual framework, regulatory activity mapping, sampling, and recruitment strategies.
- Oversee project management, timeline development, technical deliverables, budget alignment, and cross-partner coordination for a 54-month contract.
- Direct the development of pilot instruments and analytic approaches to support large-scale data collection in later phases of the study.
- Lead preparation of technical memos, regulatory summaries, expert panel materials, and monthly progress reporting.

External Evaluator (Contract)

EZRC Consulting and Sponsors for Educational Opportunity (SEO) (July 2025 – Present)

- Served as the external evaluator for SEO's college access and success programs, working closely with funder and implementer leadership.
- Led quantitative analysis and supported study design to assess program implementation, outcomes, and scalability.
- Translated analytic findings into clear, decision-relevant insights for funders and program leadership.

Lead Analyst, Measuring and Improving Postsecondary Value (Contract)

SOVA Solutions and the University Innovation Alliance (UIA) (January 2026 – Present)

- Led metrics data collection, reporting, and survey analytics across a network of member colleges, assuming full ownership midstream and ensuring continuity of deliverables.
- Designed and executed college outreach strategies, tracked submissions, and validated data quality.
- Responsible for analyzing data collected from colleges to produce institution-level reports and cross-college summaries.
- Responsible for developing and fielding a multi-phase survey, including instrument design, programming, testing, fielding, and analysis.
- Responsible for analyzing survey responses, including open ended qualitative responses.

- Served as primary point of contact for the client, coordinating reviews, approvals, and recommendations for leadership decision-making.

Economist

American Institutes for Research (AIR) (July 2021– March 2025) - Select Project Work:

Project Director and Quantitative Lead:

U.S. Department of Education Postsecondary Student Success Grant, ACCE Evaluation, Portland State University

- Designed and led an RCT of a transfer student coaching program across three institutions in Oregon
- Oversaw a \$1.2 million project budget and coordinated all project phases, data sharing, and team deliverables
- Managed client relations and facilitated cross-institutional working group meetings
- Facilitated the execution of student-level data sharing agreements across participating institutions

The National Future Farmers of America (FFA) Foundation Evaluation

- Secured \$450K in funding and led a quasi-experimental evaluation of long-term impacts of FFA membership
- Developed impact evaluation analysis plans and oversaw all data collection, processing, and analysis
- Oversaw project budget, client engagement, technical teams, and all deliverables

Quantitative Research Lead:

Competency-Based Education Pathways Evaluation - Ascendium Education Foundation

- Secured \$3M in funding; designed and led quantitative evaluation of Competency-Based Education (CBE) effectiveness
- Recruited and coordinated with two- and four-year colleges participating in the study

Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation – Network for School Improvement Evaluation

- Managed data acquisition from Texas school districts and the National Student Clearinghouse
- Designed student surveys, conducted impact analyses (PSM, diff-in-diff), and co-authored final report and presentations

Researcher:

- ***National Center for Education Statistics:*** Advised study directors and reviewed survey instruments, designs, and data processing and imputation plans for longitudinal studies
- ***Systematic Review of Sectoral Training Programs***
- ***RESEA (Department of Labor):*** Estimated precision of predictive models for the Reemployment Services and Eligibility Assessment Evidence Building Portfolio
- ***NECTEP:*** Designed measures of Labor Market Alignment of high school CTE programs to local labor markets, National Evaluation of CTE under Perkins V
- Led quantitative analysis for the Urban Teachers RCT and IDEA Public Schools Math Curriculum Redesign RCT under U.S. Dept. of Education grants

Instructor & Teaching Assistant

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (2016–2021)

- Taught two standalone upper-level economics courses (Economics of the Workplace (ECON 447) and Employee Compensation and Incentives (ECON 448))
- Led weekly discussion sections as a TA for Principals of Microeconomics
- Created instructional materials and assessments, and supported over 100 students per semester

Graduate Research Assistant

University of Illinois at Urbana Champaign (2016-2018)

- RA to Professor Adam Osman, *Fall 2016 and Spring 2017*
 - Led analysis of baseline data for RCTs conducted in Cairo, Egypt
- RA to Professors Benjamin Marx and Tatyana Deryugina, *Summer and Fall 2018*
 - Contributions supported peer-reviewed publication in [*American Economic Review: Insights*](#)
 - Wrote Python scripts to web-scrape Lexus Nexis, analyzed longitudinal data with more than 5 million observations from the American Red Cross, created Zip code crosswalks to link philanthropic giving within geographic areas across years

Peer Reviewed Publications and Working Papers

Calkins, A., Binder, A. J., Shaat, D., & Timpe, B. (2023). [When Sarah Meets Lawrence: The Effects of Coeducation on](#)

[Women's College Major Choices](#). *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 15(3), 1-34. DOI: 10.1257/app.20210692

“The Effects of Statewide Credit Transfer Agreements on Community College Enrollment” (*Job Market Paper, last updated 2021*) [*in progress*]

Select Published Reports

Zeiser, K. L., Bitter, C., Shaat, D., & Guzman-Alvarez, A. (2024). [Evaluation of the Implementation and Impact of New Tech Network's College Access Network](#)

Kurban, E., Wan, Y., Hawkins, M., & Shaat, D. (2024). Evaluation of the IDEA Public Schools Education Innovation and Research Grant: Math Curriculum Redesign. *American Institutes for Research*.
<https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED660017.pdf>

Song, M., Shaat, D., Wayne, A. J., & Graczewski, C. (2024). Addendum to the Final Report of the EIR Mid-Phase Project on MyTeachingPartner-Secondary Program (September 2023). *American Institutes for Research*.
<https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED657292.pdf>

Zeiser, K. L., Bitter, C., & Yang, J. H., & Shaat, D. (2022). [The Study of Deeper Learning: College Enrollment, Persistence, and Degree Completion in the First 6 Years After High School](#).

Shaat, D., Ebersole, C., Campbell, C., Licht, I.H., Middlebrook, K., Sahni, S. D., and an anonymous author (2024). [Do program offerings vary by participant traits? Insights from a systematic review](#). American Institutes for Research, PROPEL Center

Amin, S., Souvanna, P., Shaat, D., Riley, T. (2024). [Insights from Implementation Studies of Sectoral Training Programs](#). American Institutes for Research, PROPEL Center.

Select Conference Presentations

Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management Annual Meeting, *Fall 2023, 2024*

American Education Research Association Annual Meeting, *Spring 2024*

The Society for Research on Educational Effectiveness Annual Meeting, *Fall 2022*

Western Economic Association Organized Session, *Spring 2020*

Southern Economics Association Annual Meeting, *Fall 2020*

Association for Education Finance and Policy Annual Conference, *Spring 2020*